A Periodic Table of the Finite Simple Groups

Every finite simple group appears exactly once, in its simplest form. Columns are grouped by rank; the vertical axis is the field size q.

TYPE

🟥	Cyclic groups
🟩	Alternating groups
🟦	Classical Lie type (untwisted)
🟩	Classical Lie type (twisted)
🟪	Exceptional Lie type (untwisted)
🟥	Exceptional Lie type (twisted)
🟨	Sporadic groups

HOW TO READ A CELL

$\cong A_2(2)$ — other descriptions of the same group

$A_1(7)$ — the group

$2^3\cdot 3\cdot 7$ — prime factorisation of its order

AN EMPTY CELL

the group is not defined there, or is not simple, or it is isomorphic to one printed elsewhere — every group appears only under its simplest name:

$A_2(1) \to C_3$

$A_1(4), A_1(5) \to A_5\ [A_4(1)]$

$A_1(9) \to A_6\ [A_5(1)]$

$A_2(2) \to A_1(7)$

$A_3(2) \to A_8\ [A_7(1)]$

${}^2A_3(2) \to B_2(3)$

$C_n(q)$, q even $\to B_n(q)$

$B_2(2)' \to A_6\ [A_5(1)]$

$G_2(2)' \to {}^2A_2(3)$

${}^2G_2(3)' \to A_1(8)$

FAMILIES

$A_n(q) = L_{n+1}(q)$ — Linear

$B_n(q) = O_{2n+1}(q)$ — Orthogonal (odd)

$C_n(q) = S_{2n}(q)$ — Symplectic

$D_n(q) = O^+_{2n}(q)$ — Orthogonal (plus)

${}^2A_n(q) = U_{n+1}(q)$ — Unitary

${}^2D_n(q) = O^-_{2n}(q)$ — Orthogonal (minus)

$G_2(q)$ — Exceptional G_2

$F_4(q)$ — Exceptional F_4

$E_6(q)$ — Exceptional E_6

$E_7(q)$ — Exceptional E_7

$E_8(q)$ — Exceptional E_8

${}^3D_4(q)$ — Triality

${}^2E_6(q)$ — Twisted E_6

${}^2B_2(q)$ — Suzuki

${}^2G_2(q)$ — Ree (small)

${}^2F_4(q)$ — Ree (large)

cyclic
rank 1
rank 2
rank 3
rank 4
rank 5
rank 6
rank 7
rank 8
rank 9
rank 10
rank n
1
2
3
4
5
7
8
9
11
13
16
17
19
23
25
27
29
31
32
243
q

q = size of the field

Sporadic groups

Mathieu	M_{11}	$2^4\cdot 3^2\cdot 5\cdot 11$
Mathieu	M_{12}	$2^6\cdot 3^3\cdot 5\cdot 11$
Mathieu	M_{22}	$2^7\cdot 3^2\cdot 5\cdot 7\cdot 11$
Mathieu	M_{23}	$2^7\cdot 3^2\cdot 5\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 23$
Mathieu	M_{24}	$2^{10}\cdot 3^3\cdot 5\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 23$
Janko	J_1	$2^3\cdot 3\cdot 5\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 19$
Hall–Janko	J_2	$2^7\cdot 3^3\cdot 5^2\cdot 7$
Janko	J_3	$2^7\cdot 3^5\cdot 5\cdot 17\cdot 19$
Janko	J_4	$2^{21}\cdot 3^3\cdot 5\cdot 7\cdot 11^3\cdot 23\cdot 29\cdot 31\cdot 37\cdot 43$
Higman–Sims	HS	$2^9\cdot 3^2\cdot 5^3\cdot 7\cdot 11$
McLaughlin	McL	$2^7\cdot 3^6\cdot 5^3\cdot 7\cdot 11$
Held	He	$2^{10}\cdot 3^3\cdot 5^2\cdot 7^3\cdot 17$
Rudvalis	Ru	$2^{14}\cdot 3^3\cdot 5^3\cdot 7\cdot 13\cdot 29$
Suzuki	Suz	$2^{13}\cdot 3^7\cdot 5^2\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 13$
O'Nan	O′N	$2^9\cdot 3^4\cdot 5\cdot 7^3\cdot 11\cdot 19\cdot 31$
Conway	Co_1	$2^{21}\cdot 3^9\cdot 5^4\cdot 7^2\cdot 11\cdot 13\cdot 23$
Conway	Co_2	$2^{18}\cdot 3^6\cdot 5^3\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 23$
Conway	Co_3	$2^{10}\cdot 3^7\cdot 5^3\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 23$
Fischer	Fi_{22}	$2^{17}\cdot 3^9\cdot 5^2\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 13$
Fischer	Fi_{23}	$2^{18}\cdot 3^{13}\cdot 5^2\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 13\cdot 17\cdot 23$
Fischer	Fi_{24}'	$2^{21}\cdot 3^{16}\cdot 5^2\cdot 7^3\cdot 11\cdot 13\cdot 17\cdot 23\cdot 29$
Harada–Norton	HN	$2^{14}\cdot 3^6\cdot 5^6\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 19$
Lyons	Ly	$2^8\cdot 3^7\cdot 5^6\cdot 7\cdot 11\cdot 31\cdot 37\cdot 67$
Thompson	Th	$2^{15}\cdot 3^{10}\cdot 5^3\cdot 7^2\cdot 13\cdot 19\cdot 31$
Baby Monster	B	$2^{41}\cdot 3^{13}\cdot 5^6\cdot 7^2\cdot 11\cdot 13\cdot 17\cdot 19\cdot 23\cdot 31\cdot 47$
Monster	M	$2^{46}\cdot 3^{20}\cdot 5^9\cdot 7^6\cdot 11^2\cdot 13^3\cdot 17\cdot 19\cdot 23\cdot 29\cdot 31\cdot 41\cdot 47\cdot 59\cdot 71$

CLASSIFICATION THEOREM

Every finite simple group is cyclic of prime order, alternating of degree n ≥ 5, a group of Lie type, or one of the 26 sporadic groups. This poster shows every one of them, each exactly once.

NOTES

- After the cyclic column the columns are grouped by rank: every family with a simple group of rank 1, then of rank 2, and so on.
- E_8 is the last family to appear, so from rank 9 onwards every block is the same six classical families — hence the ellipsis.
- Row q = 1: over “the field with one element” a group of Lie type degenerates to its Weyl group, and the cell $A_n(1)$ holds the alternating group A_{n+1}. Only type A is simple there, so that row is exactly the alternating groups.
- A cell carrying a parameter shows the generic order formula in place of a prime factorisation, and so does a cell whose factorisation is too long to print.
- The rows past q = 13 are selected larger prime powers, chosen so that the Suzuki and Ree columns — which exist only for $q = 2^{2m+1}$ and $q = 3^{2m+1}$ — carry more than one group each.
- $C_n(q) \cong B_n(q)$ for q even, so only the odd-q cells of the C columns are printed.
- ${}^2B_2(q)$ and ${}^2F_4(q)$ exist for $q = 2^{2m+1}$ and ${}^2G_2(q)$ for $q = 3^{2m+1}$ (m ≥ 1); their other rows are empty.
- ${}^2F_4(2)$ is not simple, but its derived subgroup — the Tits group — is, and is printed in that cell.
- The 26 sporadic groups belong to no family of Lie type; they are shown in their own strip.
- A symbol with a subscript and no field is a group over “F_1”: C_p is cyclic of order p and A_m is alternating of degree m. With a field, $A_n(q)$ is linear and $C_n(q)$ symplectic — the argument tells them apart.